ISSUE 3

GALLIONS grapevine

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

January 2001 • 8 page Special

A message from the Chairman

Exciting major changes taking place in Thamesmead will have a significant impact on the lives of all of us who live here.

Just six months after registration with the Housing Corporation, Gallions is set to launch a major consultation exercise, which will be the first step towards developing a strategy for long-term regeneration activities in the area.

On the 9th December, the Tenant Conference, Working in Partnership, looked at 'the vision': what Thamesmead could look like and how we could all benefit. We will be working closely with our key partners, Trust Thamesmead and Tilfen on this project.

The elections taking place for the Estate Management Boards will help establish a way for your views and opinions to be at the heart of the decision making process.

We want to actively work with the agencies in the area to improve the quality of life for those living in Thamesmead:

We have established a Community Safety Partnership with the Metropolitan police, the Boroughs of Bexley and Greenwich and local residents to reduce crime and vandalism in the area. We all have a shared opportunity to help.

Our colleagues at London Transport want to provide modern shelters at all the bus stops in Thamesmead, but shelters are often vandalised. You can help by reporting these matters to the Police.

Parents, younger people and older residents all have a major responsibility in this area. We will provide all necessary resources to improve the area but we need all residents to help us if we are to beat the vandalism in this area.

Over the coming months there will be real opportunities for all Thamesmead residents to have their say about the future needs and aspirations for those wishing to see Thamesmead prosper and become a thriving community.

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Eastenders Star Conducts Customer First Prize Draw

Six lucky winners received over £1,750 worth of Sainsbury vouchers as a result of completing the Gallions **Customer First** Survey and entering the free competition. The results of this survey can be found on pages 4 and 5.

Pictured above is Carly Hillman (Nicki Di Marco from Eastenders) and Kaye Sene from the Customer First team together with three of the prize winners, Joseph Smith, Anita Thursby and Maureen Emery. Carly presented the vouchers at the Orchard Theatre in Dartford last month.

Our congratulations again to all six winners.

See back page for your list of contacts

Lifting the lid on performance

As well as publishing the findings from the 'Customer Survey 2000', we are using this copy of Grapevine to mark the start of a more open approach by us. From now on, all future editions of Grapevine will include more details about aspects of the Association's business and performance.

We want to show you a picture of how the Association works and how we measure up when compared to others. In each issue of Grapevine you will see the information below updated to reflect the current position. We would welcome your comment and suggestions.

(All figures show the position as at the end of September 2000 for the current financial year, which began in April)

Collecting rents

Collecting rent is vital to our ability to maintain services and to complete our work programmes. Everyone suffers when people do not pay their rent. We will be redoubling our efforts to collect money owed to us on a more timely basis in the new year.

- In the current year, rent arrears form **3.99%** of the total amount of rent that we should have had coming in. This compares favourably with other social housing landlords.
- Of this number, **17.34%** were caused by people getting their housing benefit late.
- The collection rate for all rents for the year to date is **99.81%**. This is better, on average, than the collection rates of other social housing landlords.
- Of all monies received, an average of **52.81%** is received in Housing Benefit.



Rents

The Board of Gallions Housing Association is currently considering future rent policy. Despite what you may have heard or read elsewhere, NO decisions have yet been made.

Before these decisions are taken the Board are keen to consult with and take into account the views of tenants. In order to provide an opportunity for your input we are making arrangements for presentations and workshops during January.

If you would like to take advantage of this opportunity to attend and make your views known please contact John Kitchingham on **020 810 1500 ext 255** to obtain further details.

People wanting homes

We measure the demand for homes according to the different types of properties that people are looking for, such as 1/2/3/4 bedroom homes. This is based on the number of active applicants and those people requesting transfers.

In the current year to date our averages are as follows:

- 457 per month for 1 Bedroom properties
- 313 per month for 2 Bedroom properties
- 101 per month for 3 Bedroom properties
- 57 per month for 4 Bedroom properties

See back page for your list of contacts

Completing repairs

Our responsive repairs service is available to you by calling our Repairs Freephone number. You can use the service 24 hours a day/7 days a week by dialling 0800 838481

- **The Housing Corporation sets targets for completing repairs within the different priority types (see column 1). Our actual performance was better than their targets in all categories. The figures are shown in column 2.**

TYPE OF REPAIR	HOUSING CORPORATION TARGET	NO. WE COMPLETED
EMERGENCY	95%	96%
URGENT	90%	91%
ROUTINE	90%	91%

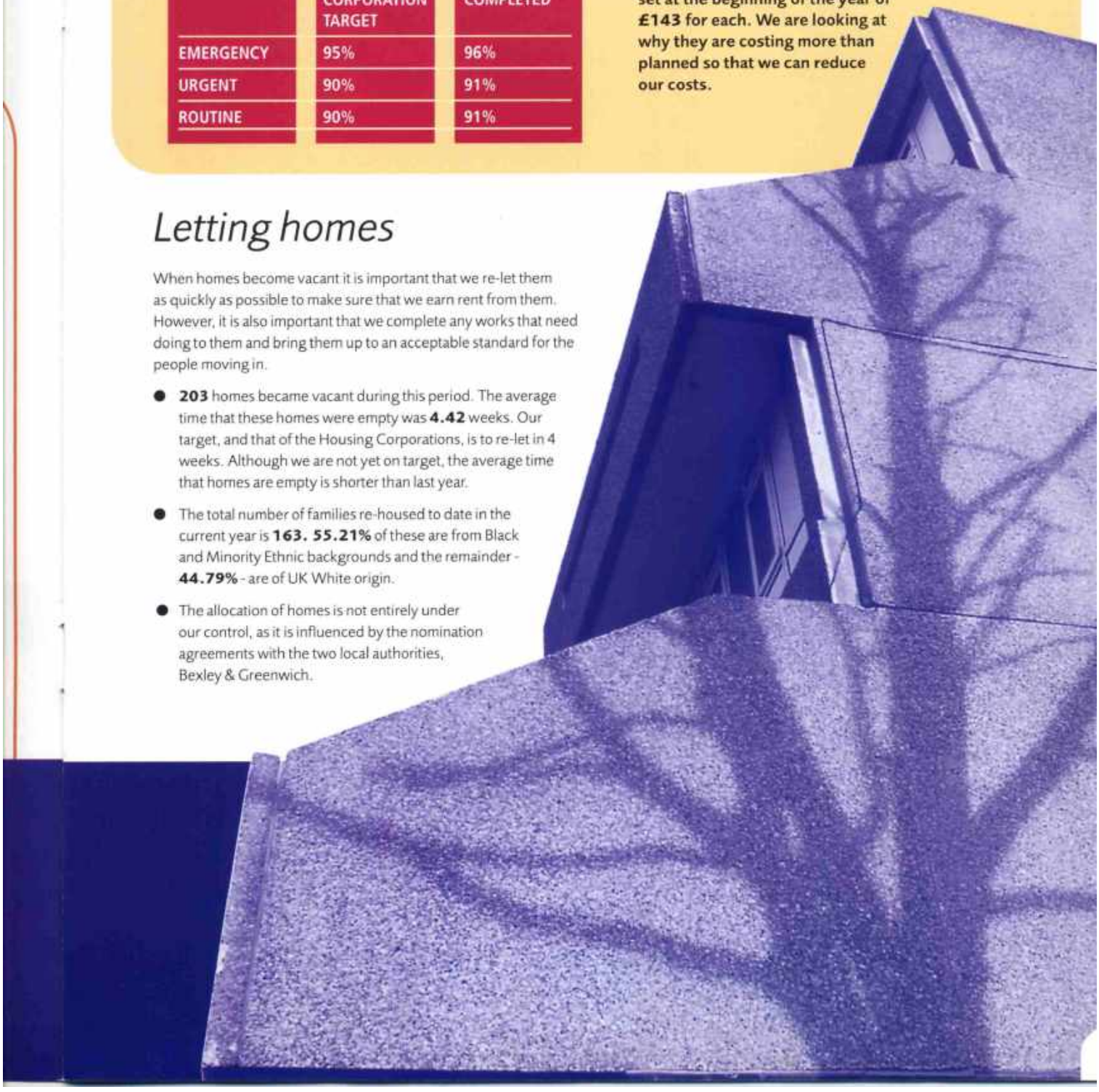
- **1637 residents completed our repairs customer satisfaction questionnaires. These are issued with each repair performed. We received 14 complaints so far in the year to date. All complaints are investigated individually as a matter of course. According to your replies, 99.07% of you were satisfied with the repairs performed.**

- **We have ordered 4126 jobs in the current year (April 2000 – December 2001) so far at a total cost of £1,027,395.00. The average cost of each repair carried out is £265 against a target set at the beginning of the year of £143 for each. We are looking at why they are costing more than planned so that we can reduce our costs.**

Letting homes

When homes become vacant it is important that we re-let them as quickly as possible to make sure that we earn rent from them. However, it is also important that we complete any works that need doing to them and bring them up to an acceptable standard for the people moving in.

- **203** homes became vacant during this period. The average time that these homes were empty was **4.42** weeks. Our target, and that of the Housing Corporations, is to re-let in 4 weeks. Although we are not yet on target, the average time that homes are empty is shorter than last year.
- The total number of families re-housed to date in the current year is **163. 55.21%** of these are from Black and Minority Ethnic backgrounds and the remainder - **44.79%** - are of UK White origin.
- The allocation of homes is not entirely under our control, as it is influenced by the nomination agreements with the two local authorities, Bexley & Greenwich.



Gallions Customer S

We have now completed our survey of customers and studied the comments you made.

One in three of all customers responded to the survey and this has given us a strong indication of people's views.

It is good to know that we are doing some things well. It is also good to know where our weaknesses lie. We now intend to get on and improve on these areas.

Remember that we are here to serve you and that we need your continued feedback. Our surveys are just one part of this but we want more. A number of customers have agreed to take part in Focus Groups so that we can listen to, and act on, the views of customers on a much more regular basis. We also have plans for further tenant involvement in our decision making so that we establish a true partnership with as many customers as possible.

If you would like more details on how you can get involved with the work of the Association, either through Focus Groups or any other means, then please write to us at the address on the back of this newsletter.

There are lots of statistics as a result of the survey and we have provided a sample here.

All in all there are some good signs here but we have a long way to go in many areas. Once again, our gratitude to those who took the time to complete the survey.

Key to graphs

Tenant

Owner

Satisfaction levels with your home and the services provided



Your prefered method of consultation with the Association



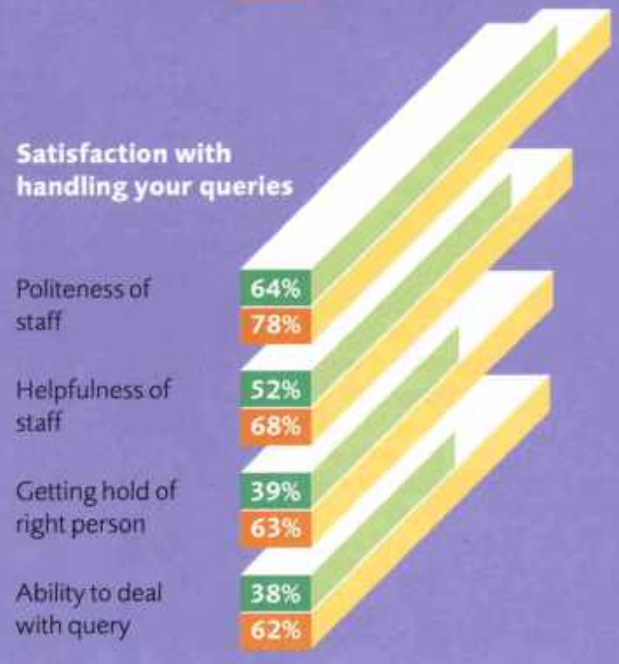
See back page for your list of contacts

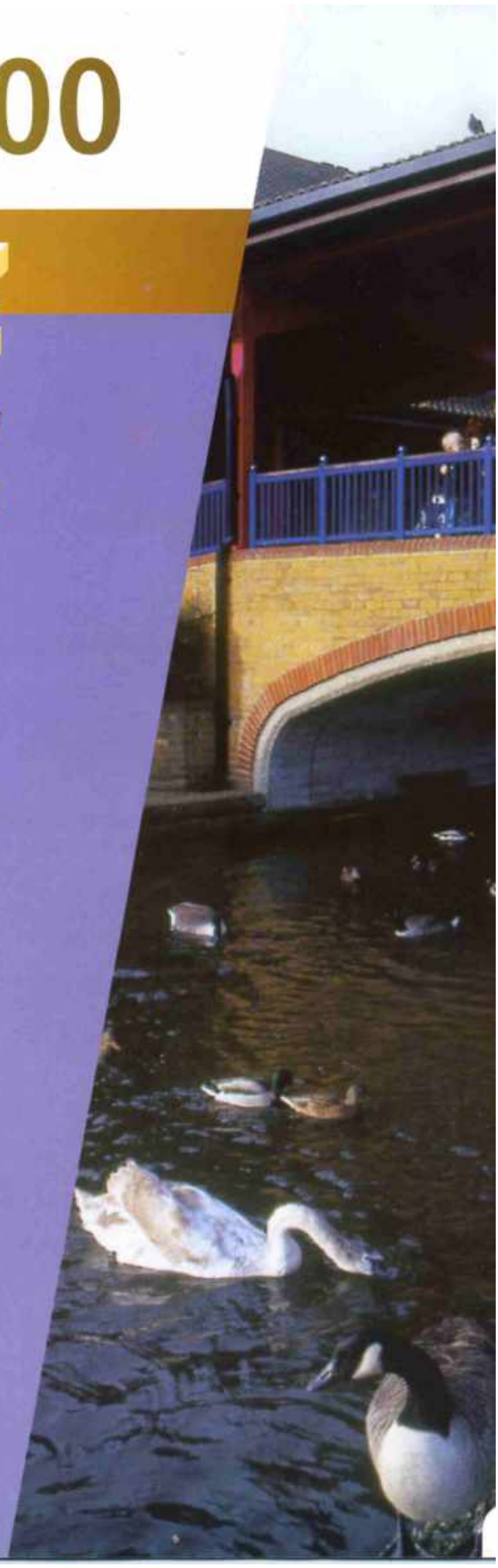
r Survey 2000

Satisfaction levels with key services



Satisfaction with handling your queries





Valuing our open spaces

Improving our environment has now become a high profile issue here in Thamesmead.

If the opinions of residents are to be acted upon, we need to do much more to encourage a greater sense of pride in the value of our parks and open spaces. For example, they are there for the benefit of all residents, not for those allowing their dogs to foul the green areas without accepting responsibility for the action of their pets.

In consultation with EMB members, we hope to establish an Environment Group in the New Year and to encourage the local councils to enforce the bye-laws, including on the spot fines for those who let their pets foul public spaces.

We are keen to hear your views, write to the Chair of Gallions with your suggestions.



Inspector Rachel Bennett

Thamesmead Community Policing Team

Your Community Officers are:
PC Tony Field, West Thamesmead
PC Matt Traynor, Central Thamesmead

Just a short article to introduce myself to those who don't already know me. In April 2000, I took over from Inspector Bob Edwards as officer in charge of the Greenwich Borough Community Policing Team for Plumstead and Thamesmead, based at Thamesmead Police Station.

Our overall aim is to work towards reducing crime and disorder in partnership with the community and other organisations. We have had a number of successes this year in this area including joint operations with Gallions Housing tackling motor vehicle crime and anti-social behaviour.

We are also working closely with Bexley Borough Police and have set up cross border initiatives for Thamesmead as a whole. This has included a monthly surgery for the Vietnamese and Chinese Community in the Family Services Unit.

I am very keen to develop community consultation, in order that we can better focus our resources on matters that are important to you. I would very much welcome you or your organisation to my bi-monthly Area Crime and Disorder Committee. This is a public meeting where I give a detailed report on the current crime issues in the area. The meeting also gives you an opportunity either within the meeting or afterwards to raise your concerns.

Alternatively, if you wish to contact the team, do not hesitate to contact us on 020 8284 9616. Whilst this is not staffed 24 hrs, there is an answer machine and someone will get back to you. If you wish to give information anonymously then ring Crimestoppers on **0800 555111**

Thamesmead Workshop

Peter Brett Associates have been commissioned by Tilfen Limited to conduct a public transport assessment of the Thamesmead area.

With the aim of developing a fully integrated strategy, a workshop was held at Gallions Housing Association on the 29th November as a key element towards establishing local needs in terms of public transport.

The workshop was well attended by a range of local representatives including relevant local authorities, Gallions Housing Association, community organisations, London Buses and Transport for London. The workshop proved to be particularly informative identifying a range of initiatives for future consideration.

Early commencement of the Water Front Transit System, the Thames Gateway Bridge and measures to improve Abbey Wood Interchange were seen as essential to the continued regeneration of Thamesmead. Short to medium term measures to improve the bus network were recognised as a critical element of any future public transport strategy. Any public transport schemes secured for Thamesmead need to be based on a long-term sustainable vision fo the area. A first draft of the report will be issued early in the New Year.

See back page for your list of contacts

Value for Money

What is Best Value?

The Government has introduced a new duty on housing associations to review all the services they provide for their residents and to improve them by the best means available. This initiative is called Best Value. Under Best Value housing associations have to consult their residents on all their services, compare with other service providers, challenge the need to provide services and to ensure services are competitive.



Best Value Team: (left to right) Lynn Bekir, James Edwards, Paul Coates and Zena Lee.

What is Gallions Doing?

Gallions Housing Association has responded to this initiative by establishing a Best Value Team. This team will carry out a full review of all the services that we provide to over the next five years. The team members are Lynn Bekir, James Edwards, Paul Coates and Zena Lee. You can speak to us about the Best Value project by calling 020 8320 3435.

The objective of the Best Value Team is to focus on the quality and efficiency of services and to strive for continuous improvements year on year. We look forward to improving and developing the services we provide and invite all of you to have your say through consultation initiatives that will be developed. More news on this will follow.

The First Service Review

The Best Value Team is currently reviewing our Homeowner service. We have already conducted a questionnaire to find out the opinions of homeowners who pay charges to Gallions. The results of this Homeowner questionnaire are being analysed and the findings will be used to focus our efforts on aspects of the service identified as performing poorly.

A Homeowner Focus Group was set up following the questionnaire in October and is made up of 10 residents who are charge-paying homeowners living in Thamesmead. The group discusses the service and its strengths and weaknesses and aims to identify a set of recommendations (from a service user's perspective) that will help shape the new service.

Visits to other housing organisations have been taking place so that we can look at the ways they provide their Homeowner services. Any good practices identified will be assessed for adoption into our new and improved service.

The team will complete its Homeowner review by March 2001. Further updates will appear in Grapevine informing you of our progress, findings and future reviews. Once again please do not hesitate to contact us to discuss any aspect of our Best Value work.

Just for fun

wordsearch

Can you find the names of ten English rivers? The names can be found across, down, up or diagonally in either direction

L	T	N	E	R	T	Y	R	X	L	V	U
M	N	O	C	L	V	B	T	U	N	N	T
R	R	T	V	C	O	L	T	U	C	V	L
E	V	P	P	N	T	C	L	P	O	E	Y
B	R	C	T	O	C	X	T	S	E	T	X
M	N	O	R	H	C	L	O	V	M	Y	S
U	E	X	T	Q	A	Q	E	E	T	N	L
H	P	R	L	O	V	M	X	V	R	E	C
X	T	L	S	E	Q	V	E	R	L	R	P
L	C	L	N	E	X	Y	Z	S	T	R	E
C	Y	T	V	R	Y	H	B	T	C	L	Y
R	N	T	N	O	V	A	V	L	C	C	W

Board Meetings

Thursdays at 6.30pm – Gallions Housing Association offices unless otherwise specified.

- 15 February 2001
- 12 April 2001
- 14 June 2001
- 16 August 2001
- 18 October 2001
- 13 December 2001



Recruitment Open Day

Gallions Housing Association held its first ever Recruitment Open Day on Friday 17th November as part of a recruitment campaign developed to attract people into the new organisation. It was a unique opportunity to provide potential applicants with a personal view of what the Association is currently doing, and our plans and ambitions for the future.

Key managers and personnel were present within an informal setting to discuss the various posts being advertised and to advise on the Association's current transition to fundamentally re-engineer the business processes and realign the services we provide to continually put our customers first in everything we do.





Around 50 people attended the event throughout the day and found it useful and informative.

Contacts

Gallions Housing Association
Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH

Office opening hours:
Monday to Friday between 9am and 5pm.

Main Switchboard
(for housing and other enquiries)
020 8310 1500

Repairs Freephone
0800 838481

Comfort 2000 Heating
020 8320 3422

Interserve
0800 389 0154